religious denomination to a Dharmic institution. After all, as discussed in the first section of the book, the concept of a religious denomination is a direct consequence of the Protestant Reformation, which led to the recognition of Lutheranism and Calvinism as the other two permanent Christian religious denominations alongside Roman Catholicism.

This clearly brings out the problem with the application of Christian colonial linguistics, semantics and framework to Indic institutions, groups and practices since those sampradayas which do not satisfy the test prescribed by the Supreme Court for a ‘religious denomination’, but can otherwise broadly be considered sects, stand to lose out on the fundamental rights guaranteed under Article 26 that envisages institutional religious autonomy of sects/groups. In this regard, as someone who has been a part of matters of civilisational importance before the Supreme Court, I have experienced, first-hand, the problem with such an application of a Christian framework to a Hindu religious institution, which resulted in the institution being denied the status of a denominational institution and, accordingly, the freedoms under Article 26.

Interestingly, on the issue of interpretation of a ‘religious denomination’, the following is the difference between the Madras High Court’s position in the Shirur Math case in its judgment of 1951 and the Supreme Court’s position in 1954 in the very same case. Extracted below is the definition of religious denomination from the Webster Dictionary used by the Madras High Court in 1951:

> of action of naming from or after something;
> giving a name to, calling by a name;
> a characteristic or qualifying name given to a thing or class of things;
> that by which anything is called;
> an appellation, designation or title;
> a collection of individuals classed together under the same name; *now almost always specifically a religious sect or body having a common faith and organisation and designated by a distinctive name* [emphasis added].

While the Madras High Court’s verdict enumerated at least seven possible definitions of religious denomination from the Webster dictionary,